

THE FIRE NOW

Edited by
Azeezat Johnson,
Remi Joseph-Salisbury,
and Beth Kamunge

ANTI- RACIST SCHOLARSHIP IN TIMES OF EXPLICIT RACIAL VIOLENCE

With a Foreword by Christina Sharpe
Afterword by George Yancy

More praise for *The Fire Now*

‘A clarion call and a collaborative love letter, *The Fire Now* is a ferocious and diligent reckoning with newly energised forces of racism and white supremacy.’

Yasmin Gunaratnam, Goldsmiths University of London

‘An important book for the unpredictable and dangerous times in which we live. Now, more than ever, we need to understand the function of white supremacy and the anti-racist theories and practices to effectively combat it.’

Akwugo Emejulu, Warwick University

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ZED

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FOREWORD: THE HEAT AND THE BURDENS OF THE DAY¹

Christina Sharpe

in our induced days and our wingless days,
my every waking was incarcerated,
each square metre of air so toxic with violence

the atmospheres were breathless there,
the bronchial trees were ligatured
with carbons

some damage I had expected, but no one
expects the violence of glances, of offices,
of walkways and train stations, of bathroom mirrors

especially, the vicious telephones, the coarseness of
daylight, the brusque decisions of air,
the casual homicides of dresses

what brutal hours, what brutal days,
do not say, oh find the good in it, do not say,
there was virtue; there was no virtue, not even in me ...

let us begin from there, ...

(Ossuary 1. Dionne Brand, *Ossuaries*, 2010)²

The tercets from Dionne Brand's long poem *Ossuaries* (2010) that form the epigraph to this Foreword take a measure of our long time – 'what brutal hours, what brutal days' – and place the reader in the midst of momentous violence and struggle. The poem establishes *that* as the space, the here, from which we must begin, without illusion. We begin there, in the midst of brutality – quotidian, spectacular, cellular, organised and ongoing – against Black and Blackened people everywhere in the world.

The Fire Now: Anti-racist Scholarship in Times of Explicit Racial Violence takes stock of such a present, our present, and insists that we reckon with, but not reconcile ourselves to it. Edited by Beth Kamunge, Remi Joseph-Salisbury and Azeezat Johnson, the here and the now, of *The Fire Now* are not singular. Here is the 'past that is not yet past'; this past or these pasts are dispersed across multiple physical geographies – Kenya, Canada, the US, the UK, academic institutions, activist, organising and meeting spaces. Each space in and from which the writers collected here work is, 'connect[ed to] anti-racisms across disciplinary and national boundaries' (Kamunge, Joseph-Salisbury and Johnson: Introduction, this volume). The editors write, 'This book is born out of our sense that we (as anti-racist scholars and activists) must bear witness to these times of explicit racial violence: we must work towards changing our fates within *the fire now*'. We must change our fates. The fire is now: Brexit, Trump, Kenyan ethnonationalisms, deportation flights, 'Punish a Muslim Day', the British government's purposeful destruction of documents of the Windrush generation and then their pursuit of deportation, Go Home vans, the horrific Grenfell fire, drownings in the Mediterranean Sea, Black people detained, murdered in stores, in churches, while praying, walking, standing, shopping, talking on the phone, getting lost. Black life, as Rinaldo Walcott (forthcoming) tells us, is interdicted at every level. This set of prohibitions and catastrophes are just some of the violences by which we understand ourselves to be in the fire, now.

The Fire Now is an ambitious project that recognises that scholarship must take a role in our liberation. The editors and contributors recognise what Sylvia Wynter, W.E.B. Du Bois, and others have told us about the role of the university in the production and maintenance of 'our narratively condemned status' (Wynter, 1994); they recognise the stakes of inaction in the face of the overlapping and discontinuous presents that we inhabit. In recognising this, many of the contributors, then, refuse certain academic conventions of form. They know that disciplinary, geographical and other such rubrics are largely insufficient to the task of thinking anew and addressing the global attacks on Black peoples. It therefore, seems to me, particularly important that the authors attend to thinking outside standard essay form. They note that the ongoing processes and work of organising, caretaking and teaching that Black intellectuals undertake must generate forms of articulation that emerge from that work and practice. Fragments, emails, transcriptions of conversations, notes, constitute intellectual production and practices; are all practices for our lives. And, while the role

of anti-racist scholarship in Black life is at the centre of the title and the book, Black scholarship often appears here in the form of Black Study. As Derrais Carter writes in 'Black Study', thinking with Wilderson, Spillers, Gumbs, Hartman, Moten and others, 'We are writing against our demise. We are thinking, writing, and being anew. Black folk have been living experiments in freedom. This, we should take seriously. The ways that we enact freedom, the ways that we realise our freedom dreams, requires experimentation' (Carter: Chapter 4, this volume).³ Which is to say, the work that we, Black people, have done and must do is to imagine and make grace. As Baby Suggs in Toni Morrison's *Beloved* says to those Black people gathered in the Clearing, the formerly enslaved and putatively born-free, 'the only grace they could have was the grace they could imagine. That if they could not see it, they would not have it' (Morrison, 2004: 103). The essays collected here imagine and perform grace – they imagine and inhabit possibility.

Imagination is central to the work of the antiracist writer, thinker and teacher. It has always been. So is bearing witness to one's times. Bearing witness to 'racisms' dynamism, it's ever mutating forms', bearing witness to enforced precarity, the financialisation of our present and then, in whatever form, committing to ending the ways that antiblack, settler colonial and plantation logics structure our everyday lives. At its best, when it is working on the urgent project of liberation, antiracist scholarship seeks to open up new spaces for Black life.

This timely collection is in the mode of other writing and other collections that were called into being by writers and thinkers who also found themselves fashioning a response in critical times: from the work of Pan Africanists like Walter Rodney, Claudia Jones and George Padmore to the work of Black feminists like Akasha (Gloria) T. Hull, Patricia Bell-Scott and Barbara Smith who, in 1982, published the collection *All the Women Are White, All the Blacks Are Men, But Some of Us Are Brave: Black Women's Studies*. Most obviously, the collection takes its title from James Baldwin's urgent *The Fire Next Time* (1963) and *The Fire This Time: A New Generation Speaks about Race* (2016) edited by Jesmyn Ward. But, in the title and the essays I also hear echoes of Michelle Cliff's wrestling with colour, class, white supremacist logics and antiblackness in 'If I Could Write This in Fire, I Would Write This in Fire'.

Each of the writers and texts assembled here confront a sense of urgency and also a knowledge of possibility. 'What unites the chapters is a commitment to bearing witness for social change' (Kamunge, Joseph-

Salisbury and Johnson: Introduction, this volume). They are united in the urgency and the possibility that are also to be found in generations of Black people who thought and made a way out (of no way) – for Black communities. This book is in the tradition of those Black people who held themselves to account as they did the work of articulating Black freedom, from the places where they found themselves, whether that was inside or outside the academy.

The Fire Now charts some of the unlivable worlds that are being imagined and materialised, and in doing so insists on the necessity of imaginative and material practices that refuse those worlds and insist livable ones into being.

The fire is now. How do we survive it?

* * *

The editors write: ‘*The Fire Now* is above all a call for further conversations and dialogues that push us to care for more, and be better for all of us’ (Joseph-Salisbury, Johnson and Kamunge: Chapter 23, this volume). All of this is the ground from which we work and act. The sense of urgency at the time of this writing is real and it has not been diminished. It subtends the questions: How are we to practise care; how are we to attend to each other in these overlapping and discontinuous geographies and presents in accountable and meaningful ways?

The Fire Now is written in the recognition that contesting antiblackness in all of its forms necessitates a global approach. The ways that we are made precarious are not the same, but they do bear relation to each other. And rather than collapse them into each other, we might, as Keguro Macharia writes in ‘Domesticating Trump’, ‘Instead, ... try to create ways to think about blackness and ethnicity as products of colonial modernity across different geohistories. To work with our differences, across geohistories, to pursue freedom’ (Macharia: Chapter 16, this volume). It is within the ongoing daily production of antiblackness and it is within this framework and in contest of it that this important work arises.

The Fire Now is a collective plotting and thinking of the conditions for and the what must be done to make liberation appear; a plotting, performing and imagining of practices of liberation. At the end of Charles Chesnutt’s 1898 novel *The Marrow of Tradition* – a novel that fictionalises the 1895 white insurrection in Wilmington, North Carolina that replaced the elected multiracial government, drove out all but two of the town’s Black residents, and killed hundreds more – the narrator tells us that,

'There's time enough, but none to spare' (Chesnutt, 2012: 150). *The Fire Now* tells us this and it performs and encourages collective witness, collective imagining and collective work in the midst of 'relentless assault'. This urgent and necessary book locates us in the desire for freedom and in collaboration as an ethic and a practice of care for Black life.

Notes

1 The title for this 'Foreword' is borrowed from a conversation that took place between Professors Nellie Y. McKay and Francis Smith Foster. The phrase the 'heat and the burdens of the day' appears in a piece in which Foster details a public conversation between herself and Nellie Y. McKay in which they recount the course of a long collaborative friendship and the overburdening of Black women in the academy. They want to encourage more collaborative work toward changing the university and saving their/our lives against isolation and exhaustion. McKay says: 'But ... it struck me that ...

without thinking too deeply, [we can] come up with different lists of several other women colleagues, and a man here and there, with whom we have similarly shared both the heat and the burdens of the day' (Moody, 2006: 8).

2 Dionne Brand (2010). *Ossuaries*. Toronto: McClelland and Stewart. Reproduced with permission of the author.

3 For Fred Moten, for instance, Black Study does not, or does not only, happen in the university. The university, in fact, may inhibit its occurrence. Black Study happens, its knowledges are made, when we gather with others.

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CHANGING OUR FATE IN *THE FIRE NOW*

*Beth Kamunge, Remi Joseph-Salisbury and
Azeezat Johnson*

And at the center of this dreadful storm, this vast confusion, stand the black people of this nation, who must now share the fate of a nation that have never accepted them, to which they were brought in chains. Well, if this is so, one has no choice but to do all in one's power to change that fate ... For the sake of one's children, in order to minimize the bill that *they* must pay, one must be careful not to take refuge in any delusion – and the value placed on the colour of the skin is always and forever a delusion. (Baldwin, 1964: 104)¹

The UK government's quest to make Britain – in the words of Theresa May – an increasingly 'hostile environment' (Lewis et al., 2017); Donald Trump's Muslim bans and continuous silence in the face of public white supremacist movements; inhumane immigration policies and detention centres; racist criminal (in)justice systems; these are just some of the marks of the virulent explicit racial violence that characterise contemporary societies. This book is born out of our sense that we (as anti-racist scholars and activists) must bear witness to these times of explicit racial violence: we must work towards changing our fates within *the fire now*. In this introduction, we as editors reflect upon the urgency that brought this book into existence. This sets up the themes that, collectively, we were keen to explore throughout the book. As we do so, we connect anti-racisms across disciplinary and national boundaries.

By foregrounding these times of explicit racial violence as a continuation of that which came before (Burnett, 2017), this book takes up Christina Sharpe's framing of the 'past which is not past' (2016: 62). These living histories inform our understandings of the blazes that surround, and are a part of, us.

Living in the wake means living the history and present of terror, from slavery to the present, as the ground of our everyday Black existence;

living the historically and geographically dis/continuous but always present and endlessly reinvigorated brutality in, and on, our bodies while even as that terror is visited on our bodies, the realities of that terror are erased. (Sharpe, 2016: 15)

The Fire Now allows us to expose these terrorising and terrifying realities: this is a reflexive study of racism's dynamism, its ever mutating forms. The rise of Trump and the Brexit referendum are symbolic of our entry into an epoch that is both a continuation of, and characteristically different from, that which came before. This is about taking stock and bearing witness to the racial conditions in which we find ourselves. In so doing, we bring together a range of scholars/activists who share our sense of urgency, and our desire to speak back. We hope that the reader sees this collection as a handbook for those undertaking (or thinking about undertaking) anti-racist work in urgently racist times.

In *The Fire Next Time* – the book from which this work is inspired – James Baldwin wrote with his nephew front and centre. Similarly, this is a personal book, written to and for those we love – many of whom are outside academia's privileged walls. It is because of this that we begin this book by addressing the role of academia in (re)producing white supremacy: as academics connected to wider communities, we write consciously of these institutions and our institutional privilege. We write to make sense of this moment as the speed at which these unrelenting, traumatising events are unfolding has been breath-taking, requiring new frameworks that seem constantly behind current events. We write to try to put a finger on ideas which are 'nameless and formless, about to be birthed, but already felt' (Lorde, 1984: 36). We write because we are simultaneously afraid, tired and angry.

This writing is also shaped by the different ways the fire now reflects the urgency of this particular moment. We write from the ashes and embers of Grenfell Tower, where fire so quickly engulfed so many of our working-class siblings in the UK. We write knowing that those deaths were a predictable and foreseeable consequence of a society that devalues Black, Brown and working-class bodies. While a £10 million 'regeneration' project sought to superficially clad over the visible inequity manifest in the tower's structure, we know it was that very cladding – erected to aesthetically please (or not disturb) the occupants of nearby luxury flats – that saw those flames rise so quickly (Baker-Jordan, 2017). We write knowing the fire was not random: it is but

symptomatic of much larger fires, and a warning of fires to come. We think through this elemental fire as we see our people battle for *clean water* in Flint and Standing Rock, and as we watch, heart-broken, by the ever-increasing climate disasters killing People of Colour across the globe. We foreground the fires that have left so many of our countries torn apart by neo-imperialist wars, and the fiery right-wing rhetoric that continues to terrorise and silence so many of us within our daily lives.

Yet we also hold onto a fire that is cleansing, that comes from speaking up and out against the violence that surrounds us. We write *The Fire Now* because we recognise that our silence will not save us (Lorde, 1984: 41), and that our anger has its uses. We write with fire.

This project emerged through the process of wrapping up the Critical Race and Ethnicities Network (CREN). As editors, we are three Black academics at different, somewhat precarious stages, of our careers. In 2014, we set up CREN because of what we saw as a stark absence of intersectional anti-racist conversations in our various institutions. We did not believe these absences to be a neutral state of being. Rather we felt that they reflected the systemic and sustained suppression of thought by People of Colour generally and Black women specifically (e.g. see Collins, 1991; 2000). It is within the context of CREN that we began to think more carefully about our roles as witnesses. What does it mean for us as academics/activists to witness? What is it that we are witnessing, for whom and for what purpose? These questions became even more urgent after various events suggested that we live in times marked by explicit as well as implied violence. It is from this standpoint that this book is assembled.

Through their chapters, we asked the collection's authors to consider the particular urgency of the issues they raise. This is a difficult question, and needs to be recognised as such. Specifically, we recognise how uncertainty is part of the urgency: between us writing these words and you reading them, things have already shifted significantly. In other words, when discussing anti-racism within the quickly mutating context of white supremacy, we need to develop analytics that can address the many unknown unknowns. Hence, for a number of authors, as per our own vision, giving 'definitive answers' is not the aim. However, our uncertainty and urgency in talking about these issues goes hand in hand with the ways that we continue to be 'forced to witness firsthand ... wilful ignorance about the impact of

race and racism' (hooks, 1996: 17). In an age of 'alternative facts', 'fake news' and distortions of the concept of 'free speech', confronting 'the refusal to acknowledge accountability for racist conditions past and present' (hooks, 1996: 17) could not be any more urgent.

The urgency of thinking about these issues is far-reaching. Whilst we include scholars from the UK and the US, we are also purposeful in centring voices from outside these contexts generally, and beyond the West particularly. However, it is important to recognise how this book stems from a desire to respond to the rise in fascism across the West, overlooking the upsurge in fiery right-wing politics and oppression outside of the West. To truly discuss the fire now we must move beyond an understanding of white supremacy as solely located within the Western hemisphere. We know that, in the words of Martin Luther King Jr, 'injustice anywhere, is a threat to justice everywhere'. We know too, that the impacts of Trump and Brexit reach far beyond the US and the UK and the socio-political conditions that gave rise to Trump and Brexit are not confined within UK and US shores. As one of the authors in this collection – Keguro Macharia – reminds us, we must:

push against the idea that it's self-evident why authors writing from and about the U.S. and the U.K. should be addressing Trump while authors not writing from or about those spaces should justify why they are writing ... We are, after all, still in the age – and grip – of U.S. empire. And it might be useful to think about how the U.S.'s status as [a] global power means that all those outside of North America are forced to pay attention to Trump and the U.S. (Macharia, 2017 personal communication shared with permission)

It is here, in thinking about the politics of spatiality (Dotson, 2013), that we see various privileges come to the fore. Without minimising the pain and trauma facing People of Colour in the West, we also need to realise that this pain and trauma often does not go unseen by People of Colour in other geo-political contexts. For those of us that are siblings outside the West, we say the names, retweet and amplify the hashtags, and march the streets, but this is often unreciprocated. As editors, we were intentional about speaking across difference and including as many voices as possible, particularly the voices that are assumed to be marginal to these conversations.

We must recognise that there is a privilege in even being able to write, or having the headspace to do so. Not only does writing in the context of a blazing fire require a room of one's own, and the ability to (calmly) sit and write as the fires blaze – it also requires a lot of invisible labour putting out other fires, whether that political labour is enacted by the people cooking or washing up (Hayes-Conroy and Hayes-Conroy, 2008), opening their homes to those on the run, burping the babies, or the labour of needing to deal with other 'more pressing' physical, mental and emotional conditions. This is an observation of the mundane, but one that bears repeating, as it is often the sort of labour that falls on working-class Women of Colour, who then end up being unable to contribute to collections such as these; but also because as the People of Colour most marginalised (both spatially and identity-wise) are putting out other fires, questions of disability, mental health, food and Queer politics fall by the way-side whilst the most 'masculine-presenting' and 'respectable' forms of activism are the narratives that get centred. What does it mean then for us to have put together a book on anti-racist scholarship, and not have trans voices represented; to know that many of our siblings are locked up in punitive penitentiary systems and yet not speak of prison abolition; to not have explicit discussions about food – especially considering the majority of those who are facing systemic hunger and environmental racism are working-class People of Colour; or to have few pieces that speak explicitly to various forms of able-ism and the multiple voices that exist outside the Western hemisphere? These are limitations that we feel keenly, and we hope that those coming after us can speak more explicitly to these and other urgent questions. As Carter (2016) would remind us, 'the ellipses of our work are always implied'.

As an interdisciplinary, international collection, the chapters represent a diversity of approaches and viewpoints, and reflect a vast range of positionalities. As editors, each with our own experiences and positionalities, we have pushed and challenged each other. Our continuous dialoguing, characterised by love and friendship, has encouraged an ongoing process of reflexivity that has seen not only the refinement of our own work, but of this edited collection. What unites the chapters is a commitment to bearing witness for social change. The collection's diversity is in many ways reflected by the myriad terminologies used throughout the book. This perhaps reflects the fluidity of studies of racism and anti-racism. Rather than agreeing

on standard terminologies throughout – an endeavour that would likely prove near impossible – we simply recognise and celebrate the vast range of approaches. Whilst the chapters intersect and interact in so many ways (and certainly across the four parts), the book is structured into four parts, as we outline below.

Reflecting our sense that anti-racist work must begin where we are, Part I focuses on ‘Transforming Academia’. In so doing, it returns to some of the themes raised above: what does it mean to simultaneously witness epistemic oppression (Dotson, 2016), wilful ignorance (Lorde, 1984), and the sorts of solidarities that ‘grow stronger in a context of productive critical exchange and confrontation’ (hooks, 1990: 6)? Aptly opening Part I, Muna Abdi provokes due consideration of the racial and racist politics that frame writing: who gets to write, and what histories shape those writings? Azeezat Johnson follows with an intervention that encourages us to consider what it means to act as academic witnesses within and beyond academia. In so doing, she argues, we must grapple with the apparent contradictions that emerge as we attempt to disrupt racial violence from spaces of racial violence. Further explicating this apparent contradiction, Jason Arday considers how racial micro-aggressions shape academic institutions, and impact upon the experiences of Black academics. Once we’ve identified the functioning of racist logics within academic institutions, we look to address the transformative potential of academia. Namely, Derrais Carter’s chapter considers how the very structure of our writing can comply to, or subvert white supremacy, before Remi Joseph-Salisbury urges us to confront our duties as academics and activists. In so doing, both Remi and Derrais point to some tangible ways to move forward.

Taking heed of Black feminist teachings, Part II is underpinned by a sense that if anti-racist struggle is not intersectional, it is entirely inadequate, and can even be dangerous. Sai Murray opens Part II, titled ‘Intersectional Identities, Intersectional Struggles’ by troubling identity monitoring categories in order to articulate the multiplicity of identities. Viji Kuppan then brings disabled bodies of colour into focus, as he urges us to understand the ways in which white supremacy and ableism intersect. In Amal Ali’s chapter, as we consider face veiling and Islamophobia, we are compelled to return to the judicial space from which the concept of intersectionality emerged. Ali’s argument exposes the increasing restrictions placed upon Islamic manifestations of religious belief: we must recognise how this happens at the

intersections of race, gender and religion. Following Ali, Adrienne Milner and Adekonyinsola Aromolaran look to the 2017 Women's March and how Women of Colour continue to be excluded from interventions that they were a part of creating: activist movements must take intersectionality seriously, they argue. In the final chapter of Part II, Leon Sealey-Huggins shows how the climate crisis cannot be examined without recognising the ways in which 'the climate crisis is a racist crisis'. Fights for climate justice, therefore, must be *anti-racist* struggles for climate justice.

Where Part II considers the connections between identities and struggles, Part III – 'Lessons from History, Connections across Spaces' – focuses on connections across spaces, and the connections to histories from which we must learn. Kehinde Andrews opens Part III: drawing important lessons from Malcolm X, he urges contemporary activists and scholars not to be so distracted by Trump and Brexit that we lose sight of the larger picture of systemic racism. From here, Layla Brown-Vincent challenges the idea that Trump represents something new or unique: for many Black people, Trump is but the latest iteration of US racism. Brown-Vincent encourages us to draw inspiration from the anti-racist movements burgeoning across the US. Moussa Traoré shows how contemporary anti-racist actions are a continuation of earlier struggles. We must embody the resistance of those who have fought before us, he argues. In order to inform contemporary struggles, Tony Talburt draws out and offers important lessons from Pan-African resistance. Sam Tecele and Carl James encourage Canadians not to be so distracted by Trump that they become complacent to the racism that lurks beneath the thin veneer of Canada's multicultural oasis rhetoric. Keguro Macharia's intervention shows how Trump-like politics are evident in Kenya, through both sexism and racism. Macharia urges Kenyans to see anti-Black racism not just as a US affair, but as an important domestic issue.

Part IV – 'Understanding and Reframing Oppression' – recognises that we must take stock of, but also speak back to, the white supremacist conditions we face. The part opens with a dialogue between three Black Kenyan women, Beth Kamunge, Wambui Mwangi and Osop Abdi Ali. Through their dialogue, the authors consider 'what it actually means, and takes, to write in the midst of relentless assault'. From here Maryam Jameela examines the ways in which trauma is racialised and whose trauma is therefore seen as legitimate. For Jameela, there

is much to do if People of Colour, and particularly Muslim Women of Colour, are to have their traumas recognised. Following Jameela, Sadia Habib suggests that British schools must act in response to explicit racisms that have proliferated in the aftermath of Trump and the Brexit vote. For Habib, the proliferation of racisms mean that critical pedagogues must challenge the de-racialised (and simultaneously hyper-racialised) policies on British values. Like Habib, China Mills problematises the notion of ‘Fundamental British Values’, and demonstrates the impact of imperialist racism on mental health. For Mills, the focus on ‘Fundamental British Values’ acts only to privilege and protect whiteness. Although this assists in nuancing our understanding of white supremacy, the following chapters focus on a de-centring of exclusionary and oppressive practices in different ways. Kadian Pow looks to how Black feminism can and does enable a sense of radical beingness through one’s Blackness: being exactly who you are, unapologetically. Through Patricia Noxolo’s chapter, we examine the complexity in the ubiquitous through our laughter and embodied experiences which re-make places that are increasingly imagined in exclusionary ways.

We began by talking about this as a book written to those we love. And so, we end the book (but not the discussion) with a letter that centres our loved ones in the fire with us, with all the tenderness and love that we feel for them. The sort of letter that is begun five times. And torn up five times (Baldwin, 1964). The political is personal – filled with faces, names, stories, laughter and the tears shed invisibly that no hand can wipe away (Baldwin, 1964). Not all of us make it out of the fire. This is not a cute metaphor. So, may this book be one more way through which you, our loves, are spared, and perhaps, survive.

Note

¹ Excerpted from *The Fire Next Time* c 1962, 1963 by James Baldwin. Copyright renewed. Published by Penguin Books and

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